



BEFORE

Europeans began colonizing the African continent as early as the 15th century.

PORTUGUESE EXPLORATION

Portuguese explorers began charting the coast of Africa in 1419. In 1575, the Portuguese built their first colony in what is now **Angola**.

CAPE COLONY

In 1652, the Dutch East India Company << 276 founded **Cape Town** as a colony where Dutch ships could stock up on provisions for their onward voyages east.



SLAVE SHACKLES

OTTOMAN INFLUENCE

Between the 16th and late 19th centuries, northern Africa was loosely under the control of the Ottoman Empire << 246–47. Consequently, many aspects of Turkish culture took root in the region. The most profound example of these was **Sufism**, a mystical tradition within Islam.

SLAVERY

From 1500 to 1880, Europeans shipped an estimated **15 million African slaves** to the Americas, where they worked on plantations or in domestic service << 280–81.

ZULU WARRIOR KING (c. 1787–1828)

SHAKA ZULU

In 1816, Shaka became king of the Zulus of southeastern Africa. He revolutionized the Zulu army by introducing strict and arduous training regimens, new battle formations, and new weapons, such as the long-bladed *assegaïs* (a spear). Shaka led the Zulus in raids on neighboring Nguni villages, which they razed. In this way he systematically expanded his territory and created a powerful kingdom that covered vast areas of the southern coastal and interior regions of Africa, which are known today as KwaZulu-Natal. Shaka was assassinated by his half-brother Dingane.



Although several European trading nations had secured coastal settlements around Africa by 1600, by the early 19th century the interior of the continent remained largely uncharted by Europeans, partly because many explorers feared contracting malaria in the vast tropical expanses. In 1820, the development of quinine, an effective treatment for the disease, allowed the exploration of the tropics. By 1835, Europeans had mapped most of northwestern Africa. From the 1840s the Scottish missionary David Livingstone journeyed extensively in central and southern Africa. Expeditions in the 1850s and 1860s by Richard Burton, John Speke, and James Grant located the great central lakes and the source of the Nile. By the end of the

Privileged few

Like this British official, government staff based in Africa in the early 20th century enjoyed many privileges, including servants who tended to their every need.



The Scramble for Africa

Motivated by accounts by explorers and missionaries of vast untapped resources in the heart of the African continent, rival European countries raced to gain possession of African territory during the late 19th century. The race became known as the “Scramble for Africa.”

century, Europeans had charted the courses of the Nile, Niger, Congo, and Zambezi rivers, and the world now knew about the vast resources of Africa. In 1869, the opening of the Suez Canal, a direct trade route from Europe to Asia, focused European attention on the continent's economic and strategic importance. This interest was intensified by the Industrial Revolution (see pp.292–95) and the urgent need for raw materials and new markets, and so it was not long before European countries began to scramble for African territory.

In 1875, on the eve of this territorial carve-up, the European colonial presence was still fragmented. There was the former Ottoman territory of Algeria, whose conquest by France had begun in the 1830s; a few Spanish settlements; Angola, which was held by Portugal, along with trading posts on the west coast; and British and French trading stations in west Africa. The Cape Colony was administered by the United Kingdom, and just north of Cape Colony there was the Orange Free State and the Transvaal. These two states were established by Boers (Afrikaners of Dutch origin), after the Great Trek of 1835–36. This was a mass migration of 12,000 Boers, known as the “pioneers,” who left Cape Colony in a search for new pastureland and to escape unwelcome British rule.

The African continent at this time was in turmoil. Much of the southern interior had been depopulated in the first quarter of the century by the territory-hungry Zulus under Shaka's leadership (see above). States such as Egypt were expanding. There were Islamic holy wars, called *Jihads*, taking place in the west. Cultural groups were being torn apart by the continuing slave trade, and new states were

emerging in East, Central, and West Africa. The Europeans capitalized on these disruptions, conquering territory with reasonable ease. In some cases, such as the Anglo-Zulu wars in 1879, they used military force; in others, African and European leaders agreed joint control over territory.

Divided continent

The competition between the Europeans often resulted in violent conflict. In southern Africa the first of two wars between the Boers and the British took place from late 1880 to early 1881 (see right), while North Africa became a theater for Anglo-French rivalry. Between November 15, 1884 and February 26, 1885, the Berlin Conference was convened by German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck (see p.333) in an attempt to settle rival claims. At the conference it was agreed that imperial powers could only claim colonies if they had agreed treaties with chiefs, and had administrative powers in the region.

By the close of the century, virtually all the continent was under European control. Portugal expanded its empire to include Mozambique; Belgium took over the enormous Congo region;

“If I could, I would **annex other planets.**”

CECIL RHODES, BRITISH-BORN SOUTH AFRICAN MINING MAGNATE, POLITICIAN, AND COLONIZER OF RHODESIA